Wild, Weird

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/48382534.

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General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra)

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Part 2 of Children of the Crystal - Light Hope's Kids AU

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by n7punk

Summary

ḣ the Crystal Castle, Adora and Catra have the necessities, but Light Hope only ever planned to raise She-ra and there are glaring gaps in what she can provide. The villages nearby find the two forest kids strange, but theyŕe also willing to help the two seemingly-unattended children.
(Or, Catra and Adora's interactions with society growing up through the lens of fashion)

Notes

ḟ you missed the first fic in this series, this story is separate from that but wont make sense without that background on the AU. TLDR;Light Hope raised Catra and Adora in the Whispering Woods with them knowing Adora's destiny was to be She-ra.
Theyŕe a bit older than eye-scratching age in this chapter .

Feral Woods Children

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

They find the village when they're young, Catra' s age unknown and Adora's not exact except for a probable birth month. Through the village, they eventually learn about birthdays and pick their own, Adora's exactly two months before she arrived in their time and Catra's the day Adora found her. The first time they find the village, however, they run through the bushes at the village's edge, observing and whispering. They're excited by their find until an adult spots them from within the town.

"Where are your parents?" he calls, seeming concerned. They run off into the woods, giggling to each other at the look on his face when Catra shouted back, "Dead!"

There are a few small settlements in or around the woods, but Thaymor is the closest, so it's the only one they frequent or where people know their faces. The residents there don't bother them about their parents anymore. Adora is pretty sure they're the weird orphan kids to the villagers, dressing and acting different from everyone else, but eventually everyone concerned by their sudden appearances has heard word that they do have a home and even a minder, just not one who can stop them from running around the woods.

Sometimes they play with the other kids, but apparently they're "too rough," tackling to win at tag and wrestling with too much ferocity , so eventually they learn that for they should mostly limit themselves to only touching each other. They can never tell when something is allowed with others. It makes tag a lot more boring, but it' s nice to be around other people sometimes, even if they're so different.

"Why do your clothes look like that?" a satyr girl asks them, pointing towards Adora's shirt and stopping them in the middle of walking away from their game of hopscotch, hand-in-hand. Adora glances down at her shirt. It's identical to Catra's, the two of them sharing what are supposed to just be Adora's clothes, though Catra is a little smaller, so she tends to wear the things Adora already outgrew.

"What do you mean?" Catra bites back, hunching a little and growing defensive. Adora squeezes Catra's hand, hoping to assure her. Her tail is getting all lashy.

"I've never seen anyone dressed like you, not even humans," the girl says. Adora opens her mouth, but Catra elbows her before she can reply. Right. *Human*. They're not supposed to say what Adora really is, or what she's training to be. The Horde might find out somehow.

"They're just clothes," Catra says, her ears pinned back now. Adora doesn't really know what the girl is talking about. They're both wearing the same fitted white shirt with gold trim around the cuffs and hems. Their pants are matching deep blues, though Catra's have slashes in them around her knees because she likes them tight but still needs mobility. It's just a shirt and pants. People here wear shirts and pants.

"They're so tight and blocky and they shimmer weird. White's rare, too. It's expensive," the girl says. Okay, now Adora is on board with Catra. It's just *fabric*. It doesn't shimmer. Anything can catch the light under the right circumstances. Since when are colors expensive?

"Well, what *should* our clothes look like?" she asks. The little girl blinks and then stands up, stomping her hooves a little as she turns in a slow circle until she spots one of the few human women in the village. She points to her.

"Humans look like that," she says. Adora squints in her direction. A plain green vest tucked into a yellow skirt, a long-sleeve beige shirt beneath it. None of it clings to her body like their clothes do, only

gathering at her waist, and it doesn't look particularly stretchy , either. She wears lace-up sandals, very different from Adora's boots.

"Y eah, well, that's not all they have to wear," Catra returns, drifting closer to Adora's side to sulk.

"Why are you wearing human clothes, then? Aren't they uncomfortable?" the girl asks. Adora looks to Catra. She hasn't really thought about that much. Aside from Catra telling her the moment Adora tried to offer her shoes that she doesn't want them, she has always worn Adora's clothes, at least ever since she outgrew her original ones.

"I' s all we have," Catra says, her voice sounding weirdly ashamed. Adora frowns. Has Catra *wanted* other clothes?

"Y ou should talk to the tailor! If she can make clothes for satyrs and humans, she can definitely manage you," the girl says, brightening. Adora frowns.

"T ailor?" she asks. The girl nods, waving for them to follow . Adora tries to exchange a look with Catra, but she still looks sulky and doesn't return it, just shrugging. Adora squeezes her hand, pulling them both after the little girl. They weave through the large domes of the village, eventually stopping at one with some fabrics and finished pieces of clothing displayed just inside the entrance.

"This is Caprellia' s shop! She makes a lot of the clothes in the village," the girl declares with some sense of pride. Adora looks at Catra, and this time Catra glances back, seeming unsure but a little hopeful. At least, Adora thinks that's what it means when her eyes are big like that.

She is *going* to make sure Catra has her own clothes. She nods to the girl and then marches in, determined. She immediately feels lost. There's a shop counter – she knows those, they cant af ford anything from them – and then rows and rows of fabrics and weird training dummies draped with clothes like the what villagers wear. Behind all

that there are big tables and some machines Adora has never seen before, a small living space tucked off to the side that an older satyr woman emerges from, spotting them and smiling warmly.

There's this thing the adults in the village do when looking at them sometimes where they smile at them but their eyes dont look like they mean it, weirdly sad. t might just be a satyr thing, though. Adora asked Light Hope once, but she said she didnt have any data on satyr body language in her databanks.

"Hey , girls. What are you doing here?" Caprellia asks, walking out from the back of the counter. Catra suddenly shrinks a little beside Adora, sending her a desperate glance. Adora straightens her back, looking up at the woman.

"Our clothes are weird," Adora explains. Okay , now the woman's entire face looks like her eyes as she glances between them.

"They're dif ferent. There's nothing wrong with that," she assures them. Catra scuffs her foot on the ground, looking down as her toe claw drags against it.

"There' s something wrong with mine," she mutters, a bit bitterly . Adora winces, looking up at Caprellia, but Caprellia just has her gaze fixed on Catra.

"How long have they been torn?" Caprellia asks, softly . Catra's tail lashes and she looks up, face suddenly defiant.

"I did that! I did that to fix them for me. They're not made for me, they're made for Adora," she explains, losing a bit of her energy by the end and cringing as she says it. Adora never realized that bothered her, but maybe it *didn't* until someone pointed it out and made her self-conscious about it. Adora never felt like her clothes were weird, either. Caprellia looks sad, glancing between the two of them.

"Your guardian can't get you anything for magicats?" she asks. Adora just shakes her head.

"She was only expecting me. She didn't prepare for a magicat," Adora explains. Caprellia frowns, her brow pinched.

"You've been together for years now, haven't you? She hasn't gotten anything for Catra?" Caprellia says. Catra sends Adora an urgent look, the *an adult's onto us* one.

"She can't leave to get anything. We have all the basics at home but... they're wrong, sometimes," Adora explains, gesturing vaguely at their clothes. Catra gives the smallest flinch, so Adora squeezes her hand to assure her without ever looking away from Caprellia. Recognition dawns in Caprellia's eyes.

"Oh! Your guardian is disabled?" Caprellia asks. Adora blinks at her. Parts of Light Hope are disabled, right? Some of the castle is still offline, waiting until Adora becomes She-ra to ensure they remain hidden. Adora nods. Caprellia straightens and Adora realizes for the first time she leaned down to talk to them.

"I guess that explains why she lets you run through the woods," Caprellia says, offering them a knowing smile.

"Pff t, she couldn't stop us even if she *did* have- you know, could leave," Catra says, catching herself midsentence and trailing off with a shrug. Caprellia looks between them, a bit of that pinch coming back.

"You have everything you need?" she asks. Adora nods quickly. They don't need the adults getting worried about them again.

"Some of it's just old. Like our clothes," Adora explains. And their food, but if she says that, Caprellia is going to think it's rotten. They're fine. The castle is higher tech than anything in the village, it's just limited by its supplies. Caprellia's eyes drop to their clothes,

slowly trailing over them both. After a moment, she squats down and reaches a hand out towards Catra's sleeve.

"Do you mind if I?" she asks. Catra twitches back, locking eyes with Caprellia and staring her down, so Adora hurries to move closer, in between them.

"You can touch mine," she promises, offering her arm. Caprellia offers her another sad smile, but then she drops her gaze down to her sleeve and looks it over with a critical eye. She runs her finger over the shoulder seam, taking the arm cuff between her fingers and tugging on the fabric, inspecting its feel and elasticity. A critical frown takes over her face as she does it, her gaze darting over to Catra. Catra's tail twitches tensely, but she doesn't pull back.

"This is a synthetic. We don't have a lot of them out here, and they aren't always the best thing on fur. They can lead to damage and breakage if they aren't weaved appropriately," Caprellia tells them, rising again and crossing one arm over her waist so she can rest her other elbow on it, tapping a finger on her small goatee. "You girls run around a lot, though, and they're good for movement like that and washing out stains," she adds. Adora exchanges a look with Catra, who just shrugs. She doesn't know either. Maybe *synthetic* is why their clothes seem weird.

"Catra, why did you cut the knees of your pants?" Caprellia asks, looking over to her with her thinky-frowny face still on.

"It's easier to move when the legs are tight and I need smaller sizes so they aren't too long, but that makes the knees not fit without pinching my fur," Catra explains, just like she did earlier, gesturing at her knees. She seems uncertain again, so Adora shifts closer so their shoulders are against each other and she can support her more. Caprellia is silent, clearly thinking it over. Adora glances at the shop counter behind them.

Shop counters mean buying things, which means money. Caprellia can't help them without making something new – what they have is

what they have, she can't suddenly make it normal or comfortable – but making things probably costs money. Money that they don't have. Adora looks around at the fabrics, wondering which ones might be right for Catra, and an idea occurs to her.

"If we brought you fabric, could you teach us how to make something for Catra?" Adora asks. In her periphery, Catra's tail waves hopefully. Caprellia smiles softly.

"I could certainly try. Do you have some?" she asks. Adora nods.

"The stuff of my shirt and pants are made from," she confirms. Light Hope has a machine that does it all when Adora outgrows her current clothes. Then they go to Catra, and eventually the recycler. Caprellia's eyes slide to Catra again.

"It wouldn't be perfect, but if you girls are going to be on your own for things like this, then you should at least know how to mend," Caprellia agrees. Adora brightens, nodding immediately.

"Okay! Would tomorrow be okay? It's late to go home and come back," Adora asks. Caprellia pauses, but then she nods.

"Just tell your guardian before you steal her fabric," she tells them. Adora exchanges a glance with Catra.

"Yeah, totally!" Hopefully Light Hope won't notice.

--

Light Hope *did* notice, but to Catra's surprise, she allowed it. "Catra would be more effective in her training if her clothes were properly fitted," she said. She's right, but that's not really why Catra wants it. She just wants to be comfortable and have something of her own. Sometimes she feels out of place in the Crystal Castle. She was

never supposed to be somewhere like that. She's grateful for it – who *knows* what the Horde would have done with her, her best-case scenario was probably just being homeless – but she doesn't have a lot of her own. It all feels borrowed, even when it's stuff Adora outgrew and there's no way she would want back.

At least she and Adora are weirdos together. The castle was built for Adora, but she's on her own just like Catra, the last First One. Light Hope has plenty information in her databanks on First Ones, so her childhood has been a bit easier than Catra's confusion over her own urges, but they're both alone and strange to the villagers. Maybe they – well, Adora – could fit in more at a human village, but Thaymor is theirs. The people there look at them strangely when they come marching into town with a roll of fabric each, but no one tries to stop them.

Caprellia takes them around the counter when they arrive and shows them how to take measurements and draft them out into garments. It's a lot of numbers, something Catra is a bit better at then Adora, but by the end they have a "pattern" drafted. It takes all day just to make one pair of leggings – which are apparently different from pants – for Catra and they look...okay, at the end. Not as clean as Adora's clothes despite being the exact same materials, but they fit better. They're actually designed for her tail slip through instead of just having a tight lit cut into the finished back. The cutouts where two panels meet at the sides of her knees are purposeful rather than at risk of fraying and give her plenty of movement to spring up. The leggings are finally the right length and a stirrup helps keep them in place. Sure, her sewing is rough and there's a noticeable difference in the parts Caprellia did to show them or fix their mistakes, but it's freeing to have something made for *her*.

She shows off her new freedom of movement by jumping up on the furniture before she realizes that while Adora may be laughing, that isn't a very good thank you. She drops down to the ground again, sending Caprellia her best apologetic look, something she doesn't put on very often.

"Thank you," she tells Caprellia, getting a beaming smile back.

"Now we can be *comfortable* and weird together," Adora tells Catra, nudging her with her shoulder. Catra manages a laugh, glancing down at herself. She is wearing a lot more white now that the top half of her leggings are white too, which apparently stands out. She looks up and gives Adora a hesitant smile. They stick out, but at least she's more comfortable, and she has something of her own. That's the most important thing to her.

Caprellia seems to notice her hesitation.

"How about I make a trade with you girls?" she suggests. They both look up at her, Catra's ears swiveling to attention. Caprellia places her hand on the rest of the fabric bolt they brought, still partially rolled out on the cutting table. "I don't have a lot of fabrics like this in my collection. You let me keep them and I'll make Catra some new clothes with them and some of the more appropriate fabrics I have," she proposes.

Catra's tail quivers. She would love more, something other than a single, slightly shoddy pair of leggings to call hers, but she isn't sure how much the fabric is worth or if they'll get in trouble for giving so much away. They have more, in addition to other clothes already made, but she doesn't know how long that supply will last. They have to stop growing at some point, right? Maybe it would be better to wait until they were older so the clothes would last longer.

Catra looks to Adora, knowing her eyes must be wide, but she isn't sure what the consequences of this would be no matter how much she wants it. It doesn't matter, it turns out. Adora takes one look at her and nods, looking back up at Caprellia.

"Okay!" she agrees easily. Catra's heart does that flutter thing she's still trying to figure out. She moves closer, because that usually helps it, and takes Adora's hand in her own, squeezing it in thanks. She looks up to shoot Caprellia a look that she hopes conveys how grateful she is too. She's finally going to have things of her own. She

cant think of anything she would want it to be more. She doesnt want a separate bed from Adora, or weapons of her own when she and Adora have already settled into whose staff is whose. Clothes? Those are with her all the time, and Adora's are uncomfortable, unlike the warm spot in her bed that Catra likes.

She feels her tail waving on its own with excitement. This might be the best thing one of the villagers has ever given them, and one time they got to try *candy*.

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Clothes take awhile to make, as they learned in their afternoon making just one pair of pants. Life would be easier if Light Hope' s machine was more versatile, but maybe that's why everybody doesnt have them. After two weeks, an adult in the village calls to them that Caprellia has been waiting for them when they pas by and they run over to her shop with excitement. Caprellia is talking to the mom of one of the kids that Adora *may* have tackled too hard once when they arrive, so they duck under a table to wait quietly , not wanting to be ungrateful. Catra curls up in Adora's lap and Adora pets her ears until the woman leaves, eyeing them but not moving any further away like a few of the people in the village do. When Caprellia produces the clothes, Catra leaps up from Adora's lap in a way that she almost never does. Usually she doesnt have somewhere else she would rather be.

"Normally whole outfits like this, especially for a new species and client Ineed longer to find the fit for , would be one of the most expensive things Ido, so Ikept the designs pretty simple. This way I only had to perfect a few fits," Caprellia says, a bit apologetically even though they arent paying her . Her warnings fall on deaf ears. Catra takes the garments with round eyes, turning to immediately shove them into Adora's arms. Adora takes the stack easily, letting

Catra lift them up one-by-one to look at them. t' s three shirts and two pairs of pants to go with the leggings she is already wearing.

Two of the shirts look pretty similar to the simple wrap style a lot of the village uses, though they're in a deep red that both goes with Catra's fur and should melt into the shadows she likes to stalk in the forest a lot better than her current white one. The main difference between the shirts is one is long-sleeve. They both share a tie around the waist.

"This style isn't great for all the roughhousing you do, but it should be a lot better for your fur in daily wear, and its sizing is adjustable, so it will fit you longer," Caprellia explains as Catra looks them over, pupils round and tail twitching. Catra looks up at her and Adora just wants to hug her. She looks so cute that it makes Adora want to squish things.

"It fits in with the village," Catra says, like it' s a *gift*. She's right, but even the more familiar style stands out with its bold colors. Caprellia nods as Catra excitedly pulls the sleeveless shirt over her current one and loosely ties it, looking up to Adora for approval. Adora gives her a big smile because her hands are too full for a thumbs up.

"It looks great!" she promises. It does. It fits in more, maybe, but it' s all Catra's own, too, and that's what she wanted. It' s something she deserves. Catra is grinning as she takes off the top and carefully tries to refold it, frowning when it doesn't lay as neatly as Caprellia had it. Caprellia has to show her how to fold a shirt like this, but after a minute it joins the stack.

The final shirt is different, somewhere between the wrap shirt and their current clothes in style. It' s fitted with a hem that flares out into three petals, one in the center and two back at the hips. It leaves a notch between the two petals in the back for Catra's tail to freely drape, and she waves it some when she realizes after holding the shirt up to her body. The color is a deep purple this time, one that makes her blue eye seem especially vibrant.

Adora can tell that it’s Catra’s favorite even if she doesn’t immediately yank it on. It’s in the careful way she holds it up to her body and folds it again. It’s easy to see why: it’s *unique*, and it’s made just for her body. She carefully places it on the top of the stack before peeking at the pants, another pair of leggings made properly out of the fabric they brought, and a pair of shorts with ties just above the knees like a lot of the villagers wear, although this time in a dark gray shade.

"Thank you. I'll wear them until I can't anymore," Catra tells Caprellia, looking up at her again. Caprellia smiles softly. She'd better. Adora would be overjoyed if she roused that reaction in Catra. She’s happy just seeing it happen to someone else.

"You're welcome. When you outgrow them, come back and we'll see if we can work something out. Everybody deserves to have clothes," Caprellia promises them. Catra immediately shoots Adora an excited look. Adora nods and smiles back. They'll figure out something of worth to trade. Getting to see Catra like this is definitely worth it. They still match partially with their pants and Catra gets something of her own.

Besides, even if they were dressed totally different, they're still a pair. They do everything and go everywhere together. The villagers call them *the girls*, a unit by definition. It’s not fair for Adora to be the only half with her own things.

Chapter End Notes

I'm sooooo normal about fabric and garment production I swear. I definitely didn't once read a 40 page PDF on the construction of Scottish clothing in the 8th century in one sitting and don't have a half dozen different soapboxes to stomp on about fabric types, construction, and the modern fashion industry.
#normalcore <3
Okay, but for real: fashion in the series is kind of all over the place, always has been, but it definitely varies by location a lot, so descriptions are based on Thaymor, specifically.

(Undometicated) Teenagers

Chapter Notes

> This was supposed to be a one shot, but a time skip just made two chapters make sense even if this one is shorter. They're about 17 here.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra walks into Thaymor alone and doesn't miss the double take an old woman gives when she realizes Adora isn't just trailing a bit behind Catra. Catra is sure she must have come alone here *once*, but...maybe not, actually. She has been in the woods alone, usually when Light Hope was preaching about Adora's dumb magic destiny and Catra was bored – or upset – but it's possible she might never have made her way to Thaymor during one of those times.

Coming to Thaymor is weird. Sometimes it feels more alienating to be around other people. She and Adora understand each other, and Light Hope is as simple as she is inscrutable, but other people are complicated. Catra has learned since they were small kids that a lot of their edges are too sharp for the villagers, their words seeming rude and their physical interactions too rough. Apparently they're supposed to have outgrown wrestling by now. How does that make sense? The Horde has failed all their attempts to breach the woods so far, but that doesn't mean you can get *complacent* and just hope you don't have to fight. Training is important, even in the form of play.

They'll never quite fit in here, but that doesn't mean the people aren't – usually – nice to them. There's definitely a few parents and that one shopkeeper they *maybe* stole from who don't like them, but everyone else is pretty understanding. Caprellia is a perfect example. For years she has helped Catra when she outgrew her clothes. She usually only has two, maybe three pieces of each kind

of clothing, which apparently isn't a lot, but it's enough for her, especially now she understands how much stuff like that should cost.

She heads straight to Caprellia's home, knowing she probably has an hour or two before Light Hope is done trying to walk Adora through controlling her sword's form. Ever since she finally gave it to Adora to begin training with She-ra, there have been more training sessions Catra can't really participate in. They still have their usual ones, of course, it's just that they have a little less free time together and Catra might be bored and not at all bitter over it.

She might feel a *tiny* bit like Adora is moving on towards her destiny, which could lead to her forgetting Catra, but it's fine. She's overreacting and it will be fine. She totally doesn't have a whole bribery plan. She's just...bored. Besides, she has seen the way Adora looks at her clothes sometimes, mostly when they come to the village. They both stand out, sure, but Adora more so. She still dresses the same as when they were kids, just in bigger sizes. Catra has had more opportunity for variety over the years and found the things she likes, at least from what Caprellia can make for her.

She ducks into Caprellia's shop, brushing aside a tapestry hanging over the entry. Inside, Caprellia is at work on her loom. She doesn't notice Catra right away, not facing her, so Catra has some time to browse the fabrics around the entrance and pick out the one she wants. It's not too hard – she wants the same one her shirt is made from – but it's made a bit harder by her colorblindness. She's pretty sure she has found the same one and not just a similar gray when she hears Caprellia notice her.

"Oh, Catra! What can- Where's Adora?" Caprellia asks, carefully setting down her work and then pausing when she realizes Catra is alone. Catra's ears twitch back. Given the fragility in her chest right now, that reminder of their twinness just makes her feel more insecure. There's no Catra without Adora.

Could there be an Adora without Catra?

"At home," Catra responds, nervously running her fingers over her chosen fabric to make sure it feels the same as her tunic. Caprellia looks concerned, making her way to the shop.

"Is everything alright?" she asks. Catra's ears twitch. No.

"Yeah. I just... wanted to give her a present, so I had to come when she's busy," Catra explains, gaze fixed down on the fabric. Her face feels warm and her ears are twitching back and giving away her nerves. She hates it. Why can't she stride in confidently and say what she wants to do?

Because she needs help to do it, and that makes her vulnerable. Caprellia could say no – probably should, for the sake of her bottom line. Caprellia's eyes follow Catra's hand, reached out with the fabric pinched between her fingers.

"You want her to match you?" Caprellia asks. So Catra *was* right about the fabric. She focuses on that victory rather than the way her heart wants to constrict and shatter at the phrasing. Yes, she does. She wants them to be as close to one as possible. That's not exactly happening, though, not with Adora so focused on her dumb training and dumber destiny that she can't pick up Catra's flashing red signals.

Light Hope noticed. *Light Hope*. Every now and then she says something, topic disguised but still cutting straight to Catra's broken heart, saying what they both know: Adora doesn't have time for her, not like that. It's better that she doesn't say something and drive her away. They never say it outright, but somehow they've still have multiple talks about it, mostly recently just a month ago. It's definitely not another one of the reasons Catra is here now.

"She doesn't need it, but I think she wishes she had something different. It's all we're ever going to have, though, so I thought… maybe a jacket, or something, that she could wear over her normal stuff, to make it feel more special," Catra explains. Caprellia's brow furrows like she's thinking it over. It only makes Catra more nervous.

Caprellia already does too much for them making Catra all her clothes.

"I could help. With making it, or around the shop, running errands. Whatever you need," Catra offers, feeling a bit pathetic. She doesn't even know what she could do, her sewing skills mostly limited to simple mending – something Caprellia also took time out of her day to teach them, though Catra knows she at least does that for the other kids around the village, too. "I'd just like her to have something from me," Catra finally admits in a mutter.

This is so stupid. It wouldn't even be from her, it would be from Caprellia, a kindness they've never done much to earn. They've never provided much for the village and they've certainly made problems. There's a boy still baring a scar on his arm from Catra's claws catching when she was playing too rough – during a game where you weren't even supposed to make contact, apparently.

Caprellia seems moved by Catra's statement, though, so maybe it was worth it. Her eyes soften as she looks at the fabric for a moment and then she nods, motioning for Catra to follow her. Catra hesitates before grabbing the bolt and bringing it with her. Caprellia takes her to the large cutting table in the back. Catra sets down the fabric as Caprellia goes digging around in a nearby dresser.

"I just got a new patterns book. How about you help me with a few errands, mending, and some of the jacket, and I get to test out translating these patterns to a full garment? Every book is a bit different," Caprellia offers, finding the book and dropping it on the table. Catra quickly nods. Regardless of what Caprellia says, she's getting the worse end of this deal, but one day Catra can thank her by defeating the Horde and making life easier for her and everyone else.

"Deal. I'll just have to be careful with when I come so Adora doesn't catch on," Catra agrees. Caprellia sends her a look that is a bit too knowing. Of all the adults in the village, Caprellia probably knows them best.

"Of course. It will be a nice surprise," she promises. For some reason, the words make Catra blush. She quickly looks down at the bolt and unfolds it. She hopes so.

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Catra is up to something. Multiple times now, she has been missing when Adora finished training. That's not brand-new – running off is Catra third favorite activity, right after spending time with Adora and antagonizing Light Hope – but she isn't being coy or broody about these times. Instead, she denies they ever even happened. She says that she *was* here, Adora just didn't look in the right places, but Adora knows all the right places to check. She knows Catra's secret spots and she even knows which ones she goes to when she's being broody and which ones she goes to when she's hoping Adora will come find her.

She knows Catra, and she's up to something.

"Is Catra here?" Adora asks, going to wipe sweat off her forehead before remembering that it doesn't carry over between forms and she's spotless underneath She-ra's shine. It has only been a few weeks of training with her and she's still getting used to her. So far, her early transformation only seems to have affected her outfit. It's still the unitard from that first transformation, though She-ra's body has filled out more now that Adora has grown. Light Hope says her uniform is "different than usual," but it's still functional, so Adora tries not to worry about it too much.

She still *might* have spent an hour agonizing over it the other night, but it's probably nothing and just a personal – if unconscious – choice since Light Hope said that she can influence her form like that. Without checking, though, Adora is pretty sure Catra is gone again and that kind of has her nervous. Was she too much last

night? It's a stupid thing for Adora to worry about. The She-ra stuff can stress Catra out sometimes too even without the weight of the destiny hanging over her head.

"No. She left approximately six minutes into our training session," Light Hope informs her. See, Adora *knew*, she just hadn't gone as far as confirming with Light Hope that Catra was lying. Catra uses a secret override entrance beneath the main door when she comes and goes on her own, but being outside of Light Hope's control doesn't exclude it from her monitoring.

"You don't know where she's going, right?" Adora asks as she swaps the Sword of Protection out for a regular sword. She generally favors a staff for going out in the woods because it's guaranteed to be nonfatal and she isn't expecting to fight the Horde, but she has been trying to use her swords more now she's actually training with She-ra's. It's not like she has accidentally gotten in a lot of fights.

"She has not shown up on any of my sensors, but they are largely limited to monitoring communications sent on the surface. The timeframe in which she leaves and returns guarantees that she doesn't leave the woods," Light Hope informs her, which is pretty much what Adora already knew. "Do you believe her behavior is cause for concern?" Light Hope asks, following Adora out of the training deck as she heads for the entrance.

"Uh. No, no, I just don't know what she *is* doing," Adora assures, feeling a little caught. She is definitely concerned, but she doesn't need Light Hope coming down on them and making things worse. Light Hope has tried a variety of "parenting" techniques, including setting rigid routines, but apparently her "data" showed that was unlikely to be successful and it *really* wasn't. Some of her scheduling helps Adora out, but Catra would rather do what she wants, when she wants.

That could be all this is: taking some time to do whatever she wants when no one is paying attention to her. It's the *paying attention* to her part that worries Adora. Sometimes when Adora isn't paying

attention to her, Catra takes whatever Adora *is* doing instead, throws it across the room, and climbs on her until Adora has absolutely no choice but to pay attention to her. Other times she just messes everything up, rearranging the weapon racks by deadliness or some other unhelpful metric that is essentially random, forcing Adora to follow behind and fix her messes until she has caught up, tackled Catra, and spent a good twenty minutes wrestling her. She swears Catra does it just to rile her up.

"Inform me if you discover what she has been doing. It is likely important information for her psychological profile." Yeah, Adora probably doesn't want to know what that looks like. She *definitely* doesn't want to see her own. She gives Light Hope a vague affirmation and heads out, emerging from the sunken entrance into the overgrown courtyard outside the Crystal Castle. The sky is slowly darkening, a few of the moons peeking over the trees. It's approaching too late to be out alone, especially for Catra who sometimes gets lost. Adora approaches the tree line, looking for any sign of her friend, but there's nothing to greet her except the whispering of the leaves stirring in the breeze.

Adora takes a breath, visually Catra disappearing into the trees, and sets into them herself.

"Bring me to Catra," she asks and just has to hope the woods will listen.

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Jackets are, it turns out, a lot more work than regular tops, especially without the person's exact measurements. They have to guess Adora's size based off of Catra's. She knows Adora is fuller in the chest than she is, a few inches taller, and has wider shoulders. She's generally a size bigger than Catra, but what First One machine sizes

translate to in inches is debatable. Catra had to secretly try to measure Adora out, mostly by comparing their own bodies, which kind of meant being all over Adora.

That definitely wasnt a *hardship* for Catra. f she was a bit much – a little too handsy, a little too cuddly, a little too clingy – hopefully it will all make sense and retroactively be normal once she presents the jacket. She' s pretty sure it will fit Adora between what she has managed to gather and Caprellia's experience. Caprellia has been working on the jacket in bits and pieces, which is the most Catra can ask for with a largely-free project. Catra did a lot of small work on the project, but it was definitely stuf f Caprellia could have done much faster. Most of the construction was beyond Catra. Instead, she has been running errands for Caprellia, or helping her father.

A lot of little things led to the final piece, but Catra is happy with it. t matches her shirt, a little unique to them but also influenced by general Etherian fashions. t has personality , which has sorely been missing from what Light Hope provides for them. They're not growing like they used to, so hopefully it will fit Adora for a long time. Catra's latest round of clothes is likely to be her last for a long time, too.

She's happy with what she has, and looking at the finished jacket, theyll match without being too obvious. She didnt know they were going to finish the jacket today or she would have brought something to bring it back in. As she walks through town, she has plan out how she is going to get back into the castle and hide the jacket without Adora spotting her. She wants it to be a surprise, or at least have some kind of reveal, and the odds of getting caught before she can stash the jacket and plan that out are good.

Maybe she could hide it just within the secret entry , make sure Adora isnt anywhere to be seen along the way to their room, and then return for it so she can stash it in their drawers. She could give it to Adora tonight that way. Her hands tighten around the jacket. Yeah, thatll probably work. She looks up from the jacket, feeling confident for only a moment before her heart tumbles and falls. She stumbles to a halt, staring across the berth between town and the trees.

Adora stands not far from the tree line, staring at Catra with her lips parted. Catra's heart speeds in her chest and her brain decides it's annoyance. Stupid Adora. She can't even let Catra surprise her on her own? Of course she has to show up and force Catra to do things her way. Clothes are the one thing Catra has, the one thing she can *invite* Adora to join her in, but Adora can't even let her do this on her own terms.

Catra's hands tighten on the jacket, held in front of her and obvious. For a moment, she considers giving in to the childish urge to run into the woods and deny that Adora saw anything when she catches up with her. Put on a front, block all questions, wait until Adora has almost forgotten about it before she finally gives it to her so it can feel like the present she wanted to give. Her tails lashes.

She wanted to give her a present.

Catra feels like her face is on fire, hyper aware of the other people hanging around who might not have even noticed them or how Adora's gaze keeps flicking from Catra's hands to her face. Fine. Catra's pride can take it. She wanted Adora to have this. It marks Adora for her. That's still a victory. It's not quite the tokens that the committed couples in the village exchange, but it kind of looks like it, and that's enough for Catra. Outsiders will stay away, thinking that Adora is *hers*.

Reluctantly, she puts one foot in front of the other until she has crossed the gap to stand before Adora. She looks down at the jacket, hands tightening around it enough for her claws to slide out. Hurriedly, she shoves the jacket towards Adora, holding it out at arm's length as Adora startles a little, looking down at the offering.

"I made this for you. Well, Caprellia did half of it, but I wanted us to match," Catra admits, staring down at the jacket in her hands. Stupid, it's so stupid. Why did she think this was a good idea, and why did she *say* it? Now she sounds possessive, which she *is*, but Adora doesn't need to know that. Catra went to a lot of work to make this. She doesn't want to give Adora reasons *not* to wear it.

"Really?" Adora asks, her voice so hopeful that it's suddenly all worth it. Catra finally looks up to Adora's face, finding her looking down at the jacket like it's more precious than even her stupid magic sword. Catra swallows, her tail starting to wave behind her hopefully.

"Yeah. It took a few weeks since I'm not any better at sewing than you are, but now you have something too and it matches me. We can fit together." *Just like we used to*. Catra likes having someting of her own. She likes being with Adora. Both can happen. Adora finally reaches out, gently taking the jacket from Catra and unfurling it so she can hold it up by the shoulders and look at it. Catra watches her eyes dart over it, filling with emotion. Finally, she looks up and makes eye contact with Catra.

With Adora looking at her like that, maybe she never needed to make it a surprise in the first place.

"*Thank you*," Adora whispers and yeah, that's all Catra needs. Light Hope can make Adora play with her dumb sword all she wants – Catra is the one who elicits this kind of emotion in Adora, and that's better than any heroics.

Chapter End Notes

Catra's outfit!. You can figure Adora's jacket lol.
To continue being sooooo normal 3 about clothes: if you have any exposure to modern sewing a patterns book might be a confusing term to you because they're a lot rarer these days, but rather than selling individual patterns made from tissue paper, you used to buy books with many patterns printed small scale inside and there would be instructions for scaling them up to your size based on reference points. They're mostly used in historical costuming these days I think but they do still exist and are really neat.

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